

FIGURE OF SPEECH

Ranging from the impassioned sophistry of pre-Independence India to the ghost-written banalities of the present, this anthology shows why the best political speeches are an archival delight



GREAT SPEECHES OF MODERN INDIA

Edited by RUDRANGSHU MUKHERJEE

Random House India

Price: Rs 395; Pages: 452

■ By S. Prasannarajan

Robert Harris' pop historical novel *Imperium*, which traces the evolution of the Roman senator Cicero, a mesmerising orator who leaves nothing to chance on his way to attain supreme power, opens with his struggle to become an effective public speaker. In the course of his

I thought to myself and foresaw I shall be totally ruined...if I were to kill Gandhiji. But at the same time I felt that the Indian politics in the absence of Gandhiji would surely be proved practical, able to retaliate, and would be powerful with armed forces... I took courage in both my hands and I did fire the shots at Gandhiji.

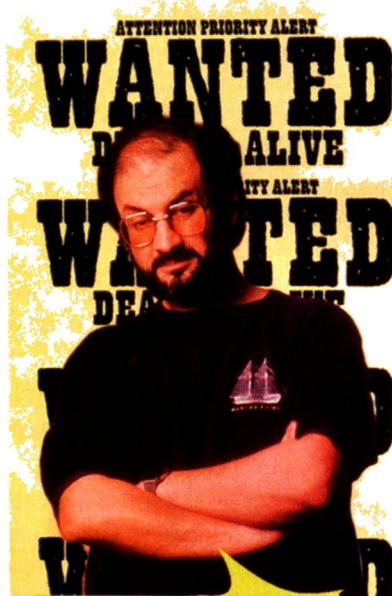
—Nathuram Godse

rigorous training, his teacher "took him down to the shingle beach, paced out eighty yards (the maximum range of the human voice) and made him declaim against the boom and hiss of the sea—the nearest thing, he said, to the murmur of three thousand people in the open air, or the background mutter of several hundred men in con-

versation in the senate. These were distractions Cicero would have to get used to." When the pupil asked him about the content, the answer he got was: "Content does not concern me. Remember Demosthenes: 'Only three things count in oratory. Delivery, delivery, and again: delivery.'" In an anthology of "great" speeches, what you get is: content, content, and again, content. You hardly get the speaker, whose mass-seductive trick, in the words of Cicero's master, is: "There should be no effeminate bending of the neck, no twiddling of the fingers. Do not move your shoulders. If you must use your fingers for a gesture, try bending the middle finger against the thumb and extending the other three...." And a written speech was pure blasphemy.

Today, even the content is more spectral than original. Except the occasional stump speeches, most of the texts attributed to our politicians and 'statesmen' belong to spin meisters and image manufacturers. Well, we have come a long way from Lincoln's "government of the people, by the people and for the people" to Bush's "axis of evil"; or from Churchill's "from Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic an iron curtain has descended across the continent" to Blair's "feral beasts". At home, good political speeches are an archival delight; no more

tryst-with-destiny or any such Nehruvian poetic flourish but only the platitudinous banalities of professorial prime ministers and anodyne



The Satanic Verses is a committedly secular text that deals in part with the material of religious faith. For the religious fundamentalist, especially, at present, the Islamic fundamentalist, the adjective 'secular' is the dirtiest of dirty words. —Salman Rushdie

inaneities of accidental party presidents. The phrase that tends to migrate from the text of a speech to the glossary of history is long dead. Indians in power badly need some competent ghost writers, at least for the sake of future anthologists. The strength of Rudrangshu Mukherjee's selection of great speeches of modern India is his editorial eye for the literary quotient: the best in this collection achieve a perfect harmony between the phrase and the philosophy. And taken together, they tell the story of a nation's life in ideas—ideas that trace the origin and evolution of freedom.

Even though the editor makes a dis-

The President has proclaimed the emergency. This is nothing to panic about. I am sure you are all conscious of the deep and widespread conspiracy, which has been brewing ever since I began to introduce certain progressive measures of benefit to the common man and woman of India. —Indira Gandhi

